NEW MEXICO

The Land of Enchantment



The biscochito—crisp, lard-rich, dusted with cinnamon sugar and flavored with anise—arrived in New Mexico with the Spanish colonizers who followed Francisco Vásquez de Coronado northward in the 16th century, and later with the settlers who traveled the Camino Real de Tierra Adentro, the royal road that connected Mexico City to the remote colonial outpost of Santa Fe. They carried with them the traditions of Spanish baking, including a shortbread-style cookie whose roots stretched back further still—to the anise-scented biscuits of the Moorish culinary tradition that had shaped Spanish cooking for centuries.

In the villages of the Rio Grande valley—Albuquerque, Socorro, Taos, and the smaller placitas tucked between the mesas—Spanish Colonial families adapted what they knew to what they had. Lard rendered from the hogs they raised replaced butter. Anise seed, brought north by the Spanish and grown in village gardens or traded at market, perfumed the dough. The cookies were cut into the shapes of animals, fleurs-de-lis, and stars—forms borrowed from both Spanish and Pueblo traditions—and baked in the adobe hornos that stood in nearly every village courtyard. They were not everyday food. They were ceremonial, intentional, and deeply communal.

For generations, biscochitos marked the moments that mattered most. They appeared at weddings, at baptisms, at the feasts of patron saints celebrated in village plazas where music, prayer, and food were never separated from one another. At Christmas, the making of biscochitos was a family event that stretched across days—grandmothers directing, mothers rolling, children sneaking dough—the recipe passed mouth to ear, never quite written down, slightly different in every household and fiercely defended as the correct version. That tradition of loving disagreement continues today.

When New Mexico achieved statehood in 1912, the biscochito was already woven so deeply into the cultural identity of its people that it was simply understood as belonging to the land. In 1989, the state made it official, designating the biscochito as the first official state cookie in the United States—a distinction that surprised no New Mexican, because they had always known it.

What makes this cookie worth making is not just its history, remarkable as that is. It is the way the anise blooms on your tongue just after the cinnamon, the way the lard gives the dough a tenderness that butter never quite achieves, the way a single bite can make a kitchen feel like something more than a kitchen. Make a batch and you will understand immediately why generations of New Mexican families have been unwilling to let this recipe leave the family—and why you will not want to stop at just one.

BISCOCHITOS

The anise-kissed, lard-crisped soul of New Mexico is proof that a single small cookie can carry a lifetime of warmth.

Yield: 3–4 dozen cookies

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup lard (chilled, for authentic texture; butter may be substituted)
- 1 cup granulated sugar
- 1 large egg
- 2 Tbsp brandy, sweet white wine, or orange juice
- 3 cups all-purpose flour
- 1½ tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp anise seeds, lightly crushed
- ¼ tsp salt

TOPPING

- ¼ cup granulated sugar
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Preheat oven*: Heat oven to 350°F (175°C). Line baking sheets with parchment.
2. *Cream lard and sugar*: In a large bowl, beat together lard and sugar until light and fluffy. Add the egg and brandy, mixing until smooth.
3. *Mix dry ingredients*: In another bowl, whisk together flour, baking powder, anise seeds, and salt.
4. *Form dough*: Gradually stir dry mixture into the wet mixture until a soft dough forms. If dough feels dry, add a splash more brandy.
5. *Roll and cut*: On a lightly floured surface, roll dough to ¼-inch thickness. Cut with star or round-shaped cookie cutters.
6. *Coat in cinnamon sugar*: Mix topping sugar and cinnamon in a shallow dish. Press each cookie lightly into the mixture before placing on baking sheet.
7. *Bake*: Bake for 10–12 minutes, or until edges are set and lightly golden.
8. *Cool and serve*: Let cookies cool on wire racks. Enjoy with coffee, hot chocolate, or after a festive meal.

